

spaces, some closed spaces. This is the way to keep the game fresh."

He further said that he is excited about how esports pros will handle the new dynamic. "This shift in strategy is something that the players look forward to. I am extremely excited to see what competitive players think of the Stepwell and how they react to it."

When asked about a move he'd pull off in Stepwell to beat his enemies, Gaikwad answered, "There is a spot (I won't tell where) which requires a bit of jumping around that will immensely help you... The other thing I try to do is get into the water, come up, look around, and then dive back in. So find that spot, and stay close to the water"

The spooky side of BGMI 4.0

Of course, it wouldn't be October without an expected spooky twist in all our beloved games – and BGMI 4.0 is no different. The Spooky Soiree theme in the BGMI 4.0 update features a haunted mansion, labyrinths, and a friendly ghost that helps you out. But for Krafton, the challenge wasn't designing the atmosphere, it was living up to expectations.

"Doing a horror or a spooky theme has become a yearly trend for us and it is actually a little toned down this year," Karan said. "The challenge isn't about how we design it, but how to manage players' expectations.

And player expectations, he admitted, are very specific. "For example, players really want help while playing. They'd want a teammate. And that is the core of this theme as there's a ghost who can help you, heal you, shield you etc. So our game design process is steeped in player feedback and expectations, and the team has done a great job of marrying both."

When asked whether the team drew from horror games or scary stories, Karan said: "It's a mix of everything. When you take inspiration from different sources, you marry it with player expectation within the context



of your game. That's what creates our unique experience in BGMI."

Stay tuned for an upcoming collaboration

Also with the festive season approaching, the BGMI 4.0 update also included features like Diwali fireworks and a Diwali exchange center in the game. Talking about the same, Gaikwad said, "There are certain awards associated with it, but the primary intention with the fireworks is a fun little Easter egg."

Now it isn't uncommon for out of the box ideas to be discussed during brainstorming sessions and never make it to the actual game. However, at Krafton, the story is different.

Gaikwad dropped a tantalising hint about the same and chose his next words very carefully with a pause. He said, "Speaking of Diwali, we have a big collaboration in store. So keep your eyes and ears open. One of our weirdest ideas actually got accepted."

Staying ahead of competition

With 200M+ downloads in India, BGMI has one of the largest and most passionate player communities anywhere. "Our players are an extremely passionate bunch and they're not shy in speaking their mind," Karan said. "We look for feedback which is repeated across platforms, channels and time. Anything which is consist-

ent in its nature and loud in its nature is something that we try to prioritise."

So, how does Krafton ensure such a large playerbase in times when there are plenty of other battle royale games in the market? The answer, as per Gaikwad, lies in constantly trying to surprise their players.

"Our development history is built on certain principles that are unique to BGMI. Just following those principles keeps our game fresh and unique. The second thing is that we actively listen to what our players want. And that also sometimes changes the trajectory of how we look at our road map.

"Finally, we are always and constantly trying to break our own rules in order to surprise players. It is a mixture of these three factors which ensures that our game is fun and fresh with every build."

The mobile gaming scene also continues to change rapidly. Expressing his thoughts on the same, Gaikwad said that they don't look at it as a problem but as "status quo".

"This industry keeps changing along multiple factors- technology, distribution, platforms, tastes, and so on. This is the nature of the beast and the job is to figure out how to navigate this change. When there is a change, you just ask your players what they want. Obviously it's not possible to take every suggestion into consideration, but we try our best." *